

DIGITAL LEADERSHIP

1 India's Digital Public Infrastructure, especially digital ID (Aadhaar) and payments infrastructure (UPI), have been highlighted by the Digital Economy Working Group (DEWG) under the G20 umbrella

2 India has signed MoUs with eight countries for extending the DPI, and 30 more have shown interest in adopting it



3 India is offering DPI free of charge, and intends to maintain a repository of DPI for future adoption

4 30 new services are expected to be included in India's DPI, and the government aims to digitise every service it offers

5 India's DPI can help accelerate adoption of various Sustainable Development Goals



T A G20 SESSION in March, India's burgeoning digital services architecture

received high praise from Microsoft Co-founder Bill Gates. "No country has built a more comprehensive digital infrastructure than India," Gates, also Co-chair of the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, said.

Just a few months later, towards the tail end of India's presidency of the G20, Gates's views had found deep resonance among almost all the dignitaries who visited the country to participate in the Summit. What was also appreciated was the leadership role India had taken in promoting access to this infrastructure, called India Stack earlier and now India Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI). The Reserve Bank of India even had a pavilion at the Bharat Mandapam where the New Delhi Leaders' Summit was held on September 9 and 10 to showcase the financial applications that had done so much to improve inclusion.

There is good reason for this recognition. What began with the Aadhaar digital identity way back in 2009—joined later by services like the Unified Payments Interface (UPI), JAM (Jan Dhan Yojana, Aadhaar and Mobile number) trinity, and Co-WIN (for managing the Covid-19 vaccination programme), among others—helped India achieve 80 per cent financial inclusion in just six years, which one paper from the Bank for International Settlements estimated would have otherwise taken 47 years to achieve. Besides, the impact of these services hasn't been restricted to just digital identity and financial

inclusion; they now support efforts in the health, education, and sustainability sectors too.

Highlighted by the Digital Economy Working Group (DEWG) under the G20, and now acknowledged as a success story, several developing nations have expressed a desire to adopt India's DPI. Keyzom Ngodup Massally, Head of Digital Programming at United Nations Development Program Chief Digital Office, says DPI is appealing to every country because each one is building its own DPI, though they are at different stages of their journey. "For low- and middle-income countries (LMICs), in particular, who may not have the technical know-how and resources to start from scratch, the adoption of a DPI approach can reduce implementation cost and shorten the learning curve through shared lessons, learnings and technologies, thereby increasing society-wide impact of digitalisation."

It is here that India is showing that it can genuinely be a leader of the Global South, as is evident from the fact that eight countries have already signed memoranda of understanding (MoUs) with India for the stack and several others, especially African nations, have shown a keen interest in adopting the payments and healthcare systems. Besides, it isn't just developing countries that have been all praise for India's DPI; France and Germany were effusive in their appreciation of the UPI at the recent G20 discussions.

GLOBAL SOLUTION

DPI isn't a new concept. It is built on foundational principles such as open source—or software with a source code that anyone can inspect, modify, and enhance—'open APIs', 'interoperability', 'privacy